

Sacks are one of the most important outcomes a pass rusher can produce, yet sack totals alone fail to measure how efficiently a player finishes once he has won his rep. The data suggests that finishing a sack is a distinct skill, separate from the ability to generate pressure or even making contact with the quarterback. Getting to him is one thing. Bringing him down is another.

This analysis introduces Pressure-to-Sack Rate (PTSR), the defensive mirror of the existing offensive metric Quarterback P2S%. Where P2S% measures how often a QB escapes pressure without being sacked, PTSR measures how often a pass rusher converts a pressure into a sack. Using Weeks 1–9 of the 2022 NFL season data, PTSR identifies which pass rushers are the most efficient finishers and whether finishing ability is related to how quickly they get to the quarterback.

Key Points: 1) Sack totals alone do not measure finishing efficiency. 2) Players with identical sack totals can have dramatically different conversion rates. 3) Finishing a sack appears to be a distinct and measurable skill separate from pressure generation.

Finishing ability varies significantly with PTSR ranges from a high of 31.8% to a low of 1.7% with a median of 13% among all qualified pass rushers. Jerry Hughes (HOU, DE) and Justin Houston (BAL, OLB) lead all qualifiers, each converting nearly one in three pressures into a sack. Houston's combination of a 20.8% pressure rate and 31.5% PTSR makes him one of the most complete pass rushers in the dataset, generating disruption at high volume and finishing at an elite rate. Jerry Hughes' 13.3% pressure rate sits below the median among qualified rushers, yet he converts nearly one in three pressures into sacks. PTSR surfaces players like Hughes whose finishing efficiency is invisible/overlooked in a traditional pressure leaderboard. Elite finishing ability also exists across all pass rush positions including interior defenders.

Key Points: 1) Speed to the quarterback and finishing ability are largely independent skills. 2) Finishing technique, leverage, redirection, and tackling ability appear to be more important drivers of sack conversion than raw pass rush speed.

Intuitively, pass rushers who reach the quarterback more quickly should convert into sacks at higher rates. Yet, there is only a weak relationship between speed and sacks but it does not explain the variation in finishing ability. Matt Judon takes nearly 3 seconds to generate pressure on average (9th slowest) yet converts 23% of his pressures into sacks, while Trey Hendrickson reaches the quarterback in just 2.48 seconds on average (4th fastest) and generates pressure on 18.9% of his pass rushes, yet converts at a below average 9%.

Key Points: 1) PTSR is most powerful when used alongside pressure rate. A high PTSR with a low pressure rate identifies a finisher being limited by opportunity, not ability. 2) Players like Grady Jarrett represent potential value, showing elite finishing efficiency in a role that may not maximize their pressure volume. 3) The central question PTSR answers is not how many sacks a player has, but how many he would have if given more chances to finish.

PTSR offers a quantifiable measure of a player's ability to finish their reps, complementing traditional metrics rather than replacing them. Used alongside pressure rate and sack totals, it provides additional context for identifying efficient finishers, evaluating the sustainability of pass rush production, and uncovering players whose underlying performance may not be fully reflected in the box score/stat sheet.

Perhaps the most actionable implication is PTSR's ability to identify pass rushers whose sack production is being suppressed by opportunity rather than ability. Grady Jarrett generated pressure on only 7.0% of his pass rush snaps yet converted those pressures into sacks at a 22.5% rate. The question for a front office is not whether Jarrett can finish. The data says he can. The question is whether his role and alignment are giving him enough opportunities to do so. PTSR reframes the evaluation question from how many sacks did he get to what would his sack total look like with more pressure opportunities.